more directly their military and economic dominance. With this, they threaten to curb the expansion of capital-imperialism in its 'pacific' form; that is, centred on localised wars and on the direct and indirect attack on any anti-capitalist initiative. The subordinate and subaltern capitalist-imperialist countries' room for manoeuvre shrinks; their area for expansion and operation has a tendency to replicate in more fragile countries the modalities of 'conversion' (persuasion accompanied by economic financing for the enhancement of their 'local' capitals) and of violence, including cutting off options through international agencies and institutions, thereby reopening tensions at the international level.

From labour's perspective, there is a crisis and also an expansion. The crisis, already shown, dispatches rare rights and increases their precariousness. As already seen, the general diminishing economic growth has up until now not shown any limitation to the processes of capital concentration and capitalisation, or aggravated falls in large monopoly profitability; on the contrary, inequalities deepen. There is, thus, capitalist expansion alongside social crisis with indiscriminate value extraction, taking advantage of all means of exploitation, from workers with contracts and rights to those with scarce rights. The fact that this process is invisible on national and international levels does not mean it disappears: every day the production processes demand greater connection among workers despite the enormous inequalities that separate them.

The BRICS personify the most impressive pinnacle of subaltern countries elevated – by external pressures and domestic demands and possibilities – to an industrialisation and generalisation of capitalist social relations that require outward expansion. Although there are internal differences among them, they all maintain a double position: on the one hand, assimilation and commitment to capital-imperialist values; on the other, a certain lack of confidence in the maintenance of current international rules in a crisis situation. A fear remains that centre powers, beginning with the United States, would pull back from 'integrating' capital-imperialist positions, on the military plane above all. Tensions between the great industrialised powers seem a thing of the past but can reappear as demonstrated by the recent episode in the Ukraine.

Notes

1. As is known, this is one of the foundations of Eurocentrism and was pointed out by Quijano (2005) as one of the bases of contemporary racism and machismo.
2. Max Weber (1983) analysed capitalism's different modes, and the most remembered is the Western rational, interpreted as the separation of family and enterprise, as rational accountability and the rational organisation of free labour. Many forget that, in the same classic work, Weber shows the irrationality of an existence turned toward restricting pleasure and satisfaction, based on the Protestant ethic and fundamental to what he defined as the capitalist spirit.